

Alachua County Animal Welfare Advisory Committee Minutes

August 9th, 2023

Members Present

Brandi Ormerod

Meredith Montgomery

Chelsea Bower

Perry Koon

Stacy Hudak

Members Absent

Amy Tate

Melissa Moomaw

Staff Present

Julie Johnson

Sarah Gilley

Faye Gould

Chelsea Meyer

Skye Barkley

Call to Order

The meeting was called to order at 1:02pm

Approval ~~*Pleasant Township Board*~~ of the Agenda and ~~*Trustees*~~ Meeting Minutes ~~*Highlights*~~

Motion could not be made to approve the agenda and minutes from previous meeting as quorum was not met. Final Agenda and minutes will be approved at the next meeting.

Public Comments

Floor was opened for public comment at 1:03pm. The following questions were raised:

- ACAR Volunteer Chris Deutsch wanted to bring attention to dogs getting time outside of kennels, stated she knew heat was a factor but wanted to ensure enrichment distribution was not a substitute for dogs getting one-on-one time with staff and dogs with behavioral problems get more time out. Requested ACAR investigates other shelters and organizations also in hot climates to see what they do in times of extreme heat. Also raised the question why ACAR had so many puppies currently in the shelter compared to previous years when they went to rescue quickly.
- ACAR Volunteer Melissa Wokasch wanted to call the committee's attention to the heat in the kennels, specifically the heat on the back row. She requested that ACAR looks into misting devices to keep the shelter cooler, that shades go up in the back yards as only yards 1-3 have adequate shades, requested later volunteer hours in the summer months to allow for cooler evening shifts. Mentioned kennels on the edges have water pooling

in from the covers during rain. Also mentioned having an easier way to document volunteer medical concerns for the animals to ensure they are being followed up on.

- Public citizen Dottie Dreyer asked about anonymous reporting, specifically if public citizens could gain access to know who in the community called in to report, stated she wanted to thank citizens for reporting cruelty. County Attorney Diana Johnson responded that public citizens can make public record requests.
- Public citizen Kathleen Rupert asked if there was a minimum number of trips/reports that need to be made for cruelty before ACAR takes action with cases. Also asked about the funds for the new shelter building, Julie Johnson responded that the money is still in our budget for use, and asked what the policy was for reporting found animals. Chair Brandi Ormerod responded that there is more information on the ACAR website with that information.

Introduction of New Staff and Committee Members

- 1:15pm – Introduction of new committee member, LEO Perry Koon. Perry introduced himself as a sheriff's deputy with the Alachua County Sheriff's Office and handles cases related to livestock.
- Introduction of new Shelter Supervisor, Chelsea Meyer. Chelsea has a background working in non-profit rescue and veterinary practices.
- Introduction of new Foster Coordinator, Skye Barkley. Skye was a previous Kennel Technician at ACAR promoted to the Foster Coordinator role.
- A new Animal Behavior and Rescue Coordinator begins on August 21st.
- Onboarded 4 new Kennel Technicians, an Investigator, and an Officer was promoted to Investigator. Just completed interviews for a new veterinarian from the University of Florida to begin at the shelter.

Old Business

- 1:25pm – Jessica Hurov, the Tourism Development Manager for Alachua County, stated the board requested that the Animal Welfare Advisory Committee look into the activities for the Agriculture and Equestrian Center to ensure practices are acceptable before implementing. The mounted shooting events were already removed. Quorum was not met at this time, determined the activities would be reviewed again during a meeting with quorum.
- Director Announcements: Heat Concerns - Director Julie Johnson made several announcements, began by addressing heat concerns. Stated heat was preventing regular playgroups, but staff is still distributing enrichment items, specifically frozen items, and taking dogs out when they can closely monitor for signs of heat distress, and there are plans in place to alleviate heat in kennels. New fans have been ordered, 2 new fans are on the back row with more coming. At the recent budget meeting, more items were approved – pet-friendly astroturf in the yards, shades to be erected over ever play yards, and splash pads. ACAR will look into misters and where they can be placed to

minimize slip accidents. The new shades will be marine shades that will be more breathable to allow air in and out and improve air flow. Addressed a dog that had recently passed at the shelter – a full necropsy was completed with no definitive results, but high anxiety levels and heat could have attributed to the dog’s demise. Chelsea Bower also responded that the Humane Society of North Central Florida has paused play groups due to the heat. Brandi Ormerod suggested signs with information on signs of heat distress, Chelsea Bower suggested retraining staff and constant reminders about heat concerns.

- Director Announcements: Intakes and Outcomes – Julie Johnson addressed public comment about increased number of puppies in-house. Stated rescue partners are also full or have cases of parvovirus and unable to accept larger puppies at this time, but pleas are being sent. Reported intake numbers are up from this time last year, primarily due to cases being completed and animals confiscated in a timelier manner. Brandi Ormerod asked if animals being fostered by finders is factored into the intake number, Julie responded yes. Brandi Ormerod and Chelsea Bower requested that the numbers be broken down further for the next meeting if possible. Julie Johnson also shared that adoption percentage is up, rescue transfer percentage was about the same. Chelsea Bower stated HSNCFI would be willing to collaborate with ACAR on microchip and/or sterilization initiatives. Meredith Montgomery (entered at 1:43pm) and Stacy Hudak requested more social media posts regarding lost/found animals, microchips to assist with return-to-owner initiatives. Sarah Gilley confirmed ACAR is looking into a return-to-owner volunteer task force. Julie Johnson stated calls to dispatch have almost doubled since last year, and certain cases require animals are housed longer. Perry Koon asked if humane euthanasia is being considered when ACAR is over-capacity, Julie Johnson stated multiple members of leadership meet often to discuss outcomes, and humane euthanasia may be considered if it is in the best interest of the animal and public safety. Sarah Gilley stated average length-of-stay has decreased to 30 days for dogs, and initiatives to push foster homes and rescue partnerships helps ACAR identify behavior cases faster to discuss potential outcomes at these meetings. Sarah Gilley stated feedback from volunteers and their reporting has also been extremely beneficial. Chelsea Bower responded about volunteers, addressed the earlier public comment about medical reporting stating that HSNCFI has a medical clipboard for volunteers. ACAR will look into this as an option for volunteers.

Agriculture and Equestrian Center

- Meredith Montgomery entered at 1:43pm, quorum was now met to allow for voting of activities at the Agriculture and Equestrian Center. Meredith Montgomery brought articles related to several activities and had concerns regarding several activities, petting zoos, bull riding, steer roping, sorting and any activities using calves. Meredith Montgomery and Stacy Hudak mentioned several items that would help make the

petting zoos less of a zoonotic risk and more comfortable for the animals in the petting zoos, including hand wash stations, no food in the petting zoo areas, and having retreats with physical, visual, and auditory barriers for the animals to take breaks.

- Perry Koon made the motion to go through each activity individually at 2:34pm.

Chelsea Bower seconded the motion. Unanimous approval.

- Barrel Racing – all in favor
- Breed Shows – all in favor
- Bull and Bronc Riding – one in favor
- Carriage Driving – four in favor
- Cattle Sorting – one in favor
- Clinics – all in favor
- Colt Starting – all in favor
- Cutting – three in favor
- Dog Shows – all in favor
- Dressage – all in favor
- Drill teams – all in favor
- Equestrian Theatrical Shows/Performance Events – all in favor
- Hunter/Jumper – all in favor
- Intercollegiate – all in favor
- Livestock shows – all in favor
- Mounted Games – all in favor
- Removal of mounted shooting – all in favor
- Open pleasure shows – all in favor
- Petting zoos – four in favor. Motion made by Stacy Hudak at 2:43pm to keep petting zoo on list with stipulations, seconded by Brandi Ormerod. With stipulations, all in favor.
- Team penning – one in favor
- Team roping – one in favor
- Western dressage – all in favor

Old Business

- Old business continued at 2:45pm with Committee Announcements - Several terms end before next meeting. Amy Tate declined to reapply. Shannon Murphy has missed more than 50% of meetings. Melissa Moomaw has reapplied. Brandi is still considering. Next meeting may involve discussion over reappointments. Brandi also mentioned the work plan is due on October 1st. We should add the ag and equestrian center (preapproved list of activities). We established committee, ordinances, meeting dates, asked if there were any goals for coming year. Any additions can be sent to Sarah and Julie to be added in.

Approval of Agenda

- Brandi Ormerod motioned to approve the agenda now that quorum was met at 2:49pm, seconded by Stacy Hudak, all in favor.

Approval of Minutes from 5/10

- Stacy Hudak motioned to approve minutes from May 10th now that quorum was met at 2:52pm, seconded by Chelsea Bower, all in favor.

New Business

- New Business began at 2:50pm with Julie Johnson asking the committee if they had any other suggestions for what the new shelter should have. Current plans include the following:
 - 300 dog kennels separated into pods
 - Adoption showcases in the lobby for long-term animals
 - Critter spaces for small mammals
 - Separate isolation wards for dogs and cats
 - Play yards with shades and splash pads

Date **January 2, 2024** Next Resolution No. **15-1-2-2024**

- ~~Call to Order -- The meeting tonight will also be on WebEx.~~
- ~~Please stand for moment of silence. --Pledge of Allegiance----Roll Call~~
- ~~Visitors --~~
 - * ~~Hanna Poling with the Southwest Messenger via WebEx. (Hanna on maternity leave)~~
- ~~Minutes to approve--No minutes~~
- ~~Financial Reports--Motion to pay expenditures.~~
- ~~Department Reports~~
 - * ~~County Sheriff's Report- Community Liaison, Deputy Adkins- absent~~
 - * ~~Road Department- Robert Bausch, Superintendent~~
 - ~~Detour approval--email received about replacing a culvert at SLM 6.94 of U.S. 62 [Pickaway County] and will require a 14-day closure of the highway, sometime in August 2024. This project is in close proximity to Pleasant township and will impact township roads via an unsigned local detour. Would you please review the report / attached plans and return a signed copy of the local detour maintenance agreement (App. C-3). This work is expected to be started and completed in August of 2024. Let me know if you have any questions. Thank you, John Brosnahan, Transportation Engineer, ODOT District 6 / Planning and Engineering~~
 - ~~Annual report SWGD~~
 - ~~Repairs truck #22-new gas tank~~
 - ~~Unresolved items~~
 - ~~Any updates on the rocks/boulders in the right-of-way on Oakhurst Dr.~~
 - ~~Any updates on Gay Rd. about repairs due to heavy rains washing the roadway and gravel away. (meeting on 8-8-23 we said we'd keep it on the agenda till resolved in some way.) Still doing work on Gay Rd.~~

▪ **Fire Dept. — Chief Whiting**

- ❖ Before Chief gave his report Nancy gave the following report of her findings. I want to try to clear something up. There seems to be some misunderstandings about the Physical Trainer and the grant to pay for this service. The following is a recap of how the grant came about from my notes, and since it's been a while, I verified by listening to the videos:

Facts

- **1-25-22** This is from Chief Taylor's report at regular meeting on 1-25-22 (Randi was absent),

The next AFG grant has been submitted. We have applied for a comprehensive wellness program and 20 sets of turn-out gear. Awards are expected to be announced beginning around the end of April or beginning of May. Totaling just over \$200,000.

- **9-13-22** This is from Chief Whiting's report at regular meeting on 9-13-22 (Nancy was absent)

We have been awarded an AFG Grant in the amount of:

\$176,882.85 Federal amount

8,844.15 5% township contribution

\$185,727.00 total

The grant will fund the following:

- additional sets of personal protective equipment (PPE)
- replace older exercise equipment
- Health and wellness exams and assessments

Once we accept the grant we will start the acquisition of gear and identifying other resources to fulfill the grant.

Trustee Sheets made Resolution 50, seconded by Trustee Good to accept the AFG Grant in the amount of \$176,882.85, the townships portion will be \$8,844.15 which is 5% of the total amount of \$185,727.00. Thank you Chief Whiting for the great work acquiring this grant saving the township over \$176,000.

- **9-12-23** Chief Whiting reported — (Randi absent)
Grant

➤ Physical trainer started working with units.

I (Nancy) have spent a lot of hours doing research about firefighter wellness programs since the wellness program that was included in the AFG grant we received has been questioned. Obviously, I had questions too thus my research.

Chief Brian Taylor applied for the grant totaling \$185,727.00. The township taxpayers are responsible to pay 5% of this grant which is \$8,844.15, leaving \$176,882.85 of Federal Grant money going into Pleasant Twp. Funds. Specific items included in the grant are gear and a wellness program in hopes of lowering workers comp claims and keep our firefighters fit and healthy. Some have disagreed and believe a wellness program with a personal trainer is not a good use of money, but as your elected decision-making trustee, I believe after much research this to be a wise, cost affective decision along with using the grant for what it was specified for, which must be followed.

~~Some questions raised are, we are running out of money and need a levy. Yes, we have not had a levy in almost 15 years, the funds are getting low. I believe we have all been very diligent with taxpayer dollars to make a projected 5 year levy last almost 15 years now. Yes, we have utilized covid moneys in the amounts of over \$900,000. Also other grant money thanks to our retired Chief Taylor and present Chief Whiting for being very good at grant writing. Keep in mind we all have stretched these funds almost 10 years beyond what we thought the last levy would last. Some think we need to cut back even more. I feel we have done an excellent job of this and there comes a time when you just can't sacrifice with anymore cuts, you have cut all you can.~~

~~Pleasant Township deserves the best service we can offer within a reasonable budget and the budget we have to work with. We have an excellent road department that continually goes above and beyond the scope of their job for the residents. To keep them they deserve to make a competitive wage which we strive to keep them within that range, not at the top and not at the bottom. The same is true with the fire department. We recently added 2 additional firefighters. Fire department operates on a unit bases, there are 3 units that rotate, work one 24 hour day off 48 hours while the other two units work their shifts. We had three firefighters on two of the units and four on one of them. On the recommendation of our fire chief the trustees hired 2 additional which made equal manpower of 4 on each shift and lowering overtime cost. The main reason for this was cost effectiveness. The cost of over time to meet state mandated minimum manning is a large part of the need to hire two more. Therefore, if one person is off we still have three on each shift, not causing overtime pay. Lots of numbers to study to understand this completely and anyone who would like to understand more is welcome to sit down with any trustees or the fire chief to understand.~~

~~I feel it was very prudent on our part to secure this grant to receive \$176,882.85 by spending \$8,844.15 out of the budget. We have gained tangible items such as gear from this money, but we also gained a comprehensive wellness program for our firefighters.~~

~~One piece of research I came across was from an article in Fire Rescue 1 sponsored by Gigna from January 14, 2020, so this isn't new. In summary of that article the purpose of the wellness program is "A successful wellness program can improve overall health and reduce costs, and it should include physical fitness, stress management and mental health elements". Firefighting is a strenuous job, and data from the United States Fire Administration identifies heart attacks as a leading cause of death for active-duty firefighters. Wellness programs can help. Various studies over the past decade have shown that an increased focus on physical fitness and overall wellness, including emotional support, can help decrease rates of obesity and anxiety—significant risk factors for cardiovascular problems. These programs can help individual firefighters be more fit and less likely to smoke, as well as more engaged on the job. The best wellness programs focus on more than just fitness. Fitness is important, but good wellness programs go beyond just exercise and include nutrition and a focus on behavioral health and stress management, because all these elements are connected. To maximize the benefit of a wellness program, be sure your program addresses both the physical and mental aspects of health. This was taken from an article written by Sara A. Jahnke, Ph.D. who is the director of the Center for Fire, Rescue and EMS Health Research at the National Development and Research Institutes.~~

~~We have really benefited from grants, a new medic, a new grassfighter, radios, turnout gear, all very necessary and expensive items. The portion of the current grant in question for a personal trainer is something we can't visualize but the rewards have been proven in healthier and stronger firefighters.~~

~~Since questions have risen about the physical trainer and the wellness program, I not only researched but I called Pete (the Twp. Legal Counsel). Pete advised we do not need a contract with the physical trainer and after I showed him the facts of how this transpired and the wording from meetings about it, he does not feel it's needed but if we want just to make it clear we could make the follow resolution.~~

~~Nancy made a motion to adopt **resolution 15** retaining Matt Wenning to perform personal training and related services for the Fire Department in the amount of \$2,083.33 per month for 2023 and 2024 to be paid with AFG grant funds and further authorizing payment for all previous services performed to date.~~

~~▪ Apparatus~~

- ~~○ E-2 @ Prairie-Ed asked how long will they have the truck, Chief will find out.~~
- ~~○ **Resolution 16** to sell the extra medic to Prairie for \$4,995. Chief research prices for trucks equal to that and that amount of money was in line for the worth of it. Also, according to the rules of the grant for our new medic, if we sold our old one for more than \$5,000 we would have to pay some back.~~
- ~~○ Tanker 231 went to All American for air leaks. (T-232 is back in service)
 - ~~➤ Additional repairs will be done in the future, including pump valves and exhaust system.~~~~
- ~~○ Station Truck oil change, brakes~~
- ~~○ C-231 tires, brakes~~

~~▪ Staffing~~

- ~~○ Resignation **Resolution 17** to accept Jesse Wildman's resignation. **Resolution 18** to accept John Kaltenbach's resignation.~~
- ~~○ Adam Lake's resignation effective January 13, 2024 he is going to Whitehall and Whitehall will reimburse Pleasant for what we have paid for his medic school.~~
- ~~○ Recommend hiring Firefighter Ben Noonan to replace the vacancy upon successfully passing the pension physical. **Resolution 19** to hire Ben Noonan as fulltime firefighter/paramedic to fill the vacancy upon successfully passing the pension physical.~~

~~▪ ○ Training center and conference room~~

- ~~○ Food and resource pantry~~
- ~~○ Surgical suite for UF with recovery space~~
- ~~○ Surgery suite for shelter staff~~
- ~~○ Separate dispatch area with locker rooms and sleeping quarters for officers~~
- ~~○ Officer holding kennels~~
- ~~○ Clinic space for public animals~~
- ~~○ Staff spaces~~
- ~~○ Quiet space for euthanasia~~

- Indoor interaction areas for dog adopters and volunteers
- Intake space
- Disaster supply staging
- 2 catios
- Welcoming lobby space
- Separate intake/outcome spaces
- 4 adoption areas for cats
- Retail store
- Laundry/food prep areas
- Foster Lobby
- Foster/volunteer spaces
- Meredith Montgomery suggested space for dental procedures
- Summer Lovin' Adopt-a-thon – Sarah Gilley notified the committee that the annual Summer Lovin' Adopt-a-thon was being held Saturday, August 12th in collaboration with the UF Chapter of the Student Association of Shelter Veterinarians.

Next Meeting

The next AWAC Meeting was set for Wednesday, November 15th at 1:00pm in the Community Support Services Center, Conference Room A.

Adjournment

Perry Koon made the motion to adjourn at 3:02pm. Seconded by Chelsea Bower, all in favor.

- ~~Paramedic School ongoing. Received a \$3,000 grant for one of our fulltime firefighters currently in medic school.~~
 - ~~Station~~
 - ~~Bay doors repaired by Compton Doors.~~
 - ~~Community Risk Reduction~~
 - ~~Numerous smoke alarms were installed in the community.~~
 - ~~One fire fatality in Township in 2023 happened at the end of November.~~
 - ~~Received an OTARMA Grant for \$1,000 for new headsets for the engine.~~
 - ~~Levy Update~~
 - ~~Starting initial planning for the educational component in the township.~~
 - ~~Communications (Dispatch)~~
 - ~~Fairfield Township~~
 - ~~The contract went into effect January 1, 2024.~~
- ~~No issues to report. Pete is working to finalize the contract. \$200,000 per year and Fairfield Residents will have soft billing for transports, which means we will accept what their insurance allows for payment.~~

- Chief said purchases were made with Twp. Card for Christmas party of \$85, he asked Paula how to reimburse that, she said a check. Chief will get that to her.

- **New Business**

- Franklin County Township Association annual dinner will be held on Thursday, January 18, 2024, at the Hollywood Casino. Registration starts at 5:30PM and annual meeting and dinner will begin at 6:00PM. Elected officials are free of charge, and dinner for members and guests is \$45 per person. To register, please send the following information for you or any guest(s) to Prairie Township at registration@prairietownship.org: full name, township affiliation, and contact information (mailing address, phone number, and email address). Preregister and RSVP by January 10, 2024.
- Ed had a call from home owner on London Groveport Rd about ODOT trimming shrubs in the right of way only they went to far and got into their yard. Ed had Robert take a look at it and Ed call ODOT Distract 6 and they will go out and look into it.

- **Announcements**

Wreaths Across America

Thank you to our Rd Dept. for placing the Marker flags at the cemeteries for Wreaths Across America. Also, thank you to Carrie Cole, a Twp. Resident and veteran, for coordinating this project. It was a great success.

Carrie Cole, Coordinator reports we had enough wreaths in December to place them at not only Oak Grove but Ebenezer and Gundy Cemeteries. That was approximately 200 veterans remembered in Pleasant Twp.. This year the Wreaths Across America service to honor these veterans will be December 14, 2024. The next 14 days is a great opportunity to sponsor a wreath because your sponsorship will be matched by a

sponsorship group. So today through Tuesday, January 16th, sponsor a wreath for \$17 and we get a second one free. Sponsor 2 at \$17 each and we get a total of 5, sponsor 5, we get 12 and

sponsor 10 we get 25 wreaths. We want you to know this matching opportunity is not listed on their website when donating, please be aware of that. A total including the matching wreaths is sent to the coordinator, Carrie Cole. To date we have 63 wreaths sponsored. 137 more are needed to honor all veterans at Oak Grove, Ebenezer and Gundy Cemeteries in Pleasant Twp. If just 11 people sponsored 5 wreaths by January 16th the goal would be met and all Veterans at these 3 cemeteries would be honored. Everyone is welcome to participate in the laying of the wreaths during the ceremony. You do not have to sponsor to participate. Your help is greatly appreciated. Please use



WREATH MATCH!

DECEMBER 16 THROUGH JANUARY 16

ANY WREATH SPONSORED THROUGH A
SPONSORSHIP GROUP WILL BE
MATCHED BY WAA!

2024 Oak Grove Cemetery Wreath Sponsorship

Every Two Wreath's Purchased WAA will donate 1 additional Wreath.

From Dec 16 - Jan 16 WAA will also match the purchased Wreaths.

Scan the QR Code with your phone camera to purchase or visit

<http://www.wreathsasscrossamerica.org/OH0362>

Wreaths are \$17 Each

1 Wreath Purchased = 2 Wreaths Sponsored

2 Wreaths Purchased = 5 Wreaths Sponsored

5 Wreaths Purchased = 12 Wreaths Sponsored

10 Wreaths Purchased = 25 Wreaths Sponsored



the link found on the Township website, Facebook page or Nextdoor to support Oak Grove Cemetery Wreaths Across America Project. Thank you.

- **Clerk Updates- Paula**

- **Resolution 20** to transfer \$10,000 from general to the medical fund.
- **Resolution 21** to request advancements for Auditor for 2024
- **Resolution 22** to authorize the Fiscal Officer to do temporary Appropriations.

- **Speaker Sheets-**

- **Adjourn at 7:45 p.m.**